

THE HARAPPAN CIVILIZATION

HARAPPAN CHRONOLOGY: REGIONAL ROOTS → HARAPPAN SPATIAL SYSTEM AND → URBAN-RURAL SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY → BUILT ORDER, WATER AND → THE HARAPPAN ECONOMY AS → INTERNAL AND OVERSEAS EXCHANGE

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g11 and all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00

HARAPPAN CHRONOLOGY: REGIONAL ROOTS TO LOCALISATION

HARAPPAN CHRONOLOGY

REGIONAL ROOTS TO LOCALISATION

LATE/LOCALISATION C. 3300-2600 BCE C. 2600-1900 BCE C. 1900-1300

INTEGRATED URBAN-RURAL NETWORK; DECLINE

REGIONAL TRANSFORMATION.

EARLY/REGIONALISATION → MATURE/INTEGRATION → LATE/LOCALISATION c.

2300-2600 BCE c.

2600-1900 BCE c.

1900-1300 BCE regional towns/crafts shared weights, seals, de-urbanisation, local ceramics, and exchange networks script.

Civilisation = integrated urban-rural network; decline = regional transformation.

CHRONOLOGY / PHASE

EARLY/REGIONALISATION → MATURE/INTEGRATION → LATE/LOCALISATION c.
3300-2600 BCE c.

MATERIAL / INSTITUTION

2600-1900 BCE c.
1900-1300 BCE regional towns/crafts shared weights, seals, de-urbanisation, local ceramics, and exchange networks script, urban systems settlement shifts.

IMPACT / LIMIT

Civilisation = integrated urban-rural network; decline = regional transformation.
EARLY/REGIONALISATION → MATURE/INTEGRATION → LATE/LOCALISATION c.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Civilisation = integrated urban-rural network; decline = regional transformation.

01

STAGE 01

HARAPPAN SPATIAL SYSTEM AND SITE ATLAS

HARAPPAN SPATIAL SYSTEM AND SITE ATLAS

MAKRAN EDGE

JAMMU FRONTIER

CORE INDUS

URBAN/CEMETERY SEQUENCE

GREAT BATH/DRAINS

PLOUGHED FIELD/FIRE INSTALLATIONS

FORTIFIED TOWN

WEST: Sutkagendor → Makran edge

NORTH: Manda → Jammu frontier

CORE INDUS: Harappa → urban/cemetery sequence

Mohenjo-daro → Great Bath/drains

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

WEST: Sutkagendor → Makran edge
NORTH: Manda → Jammu frontier
CORE INDUS: Harappa → urban/cemetery sequence
Mohenjo-daro → Great Bath/drains
GHAGGAR: Kalibangan → ploughed field/fire installations

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

Banawali → fortified town
EAST: Rakhigarhi → major Haryana complex
Alamgirpur → eastern Late Harappan edge
KUTCH: Dholavira → three-part city, reservoirs, signboard
Surkotada → fortification

DEBATE / LEGACY

GUJARAT: Lothal → basin/warehouse/craft debate
Rangpur → regional sequence
SINDH: Chanhudaro → craft centre; no classic citadel-lower-town profile

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: SINDH: Chanhudaro → craft centre; no classic citadel-lower-town profile.

02

STAGE 02

URBAN-RURAL SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY

URBAN-RURAL SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY

FARM/PASTORAL HAMLETS

CRAFT/ROUTE CENTRES

REGIONAL CITIES FOOD AND HERDS STORAGE SPECIALISED OUTPUT COORDINATION/CONSUMPTION

URBANISM DEPENDED ON RURAL SURPLUS AND RAW-MATERIAL CORRIDORS; CITIES

FARM/PASTORAL HAMLETS → VILLAGES → CRAFT/ROUTE CENTRES → REGIONAL CITIES food and herds storage specialised

+ seals + transport + shared styles connect unequal regional domains.

Urbanism depended on rural surplus and raw-material corridors; cities were not isolated.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

FARM/PASTORAL HAMLETS → VILLAGES → CRAFT/ROUTE CENTRES → REGIONAL CITIES food and herds storage specialised output coordination/consumption weights
+ seals + transport + shared styles connect unequal regional domains.

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

Urbanism depended on rural surplus and raw-material corridors; cities were not isolated.
FARM/PASTORAL HAMLETS → VILLAGES → CRAFT/ROUTE CENTRES → REGIONAL CITIES food and herds storage specialised output coordination/consumption weights

DEBATE / LEGACY

+ seals + transport + shared styles connect unequal regional domains.
Urbanism depended on rural surplus and raw-material corridors; cities were not isolated.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Urbanism depended on rural surplus and raw-material corridors; cities were not isolated.

03

STAGE 03

BUILT ORDER, WATER AND CIVIC MAINTENANCE

BUILT ORDER, WATER AND CIVIC MAINTENANCE

PLANNED STREETS + STANDARD BRICKS + PLATFORMS + COURTYARD

BATHING AREAS

COVERED DRAINS

SOAK PITS/INSPECTION ACCESS HOUSEHOLD INVESTMENT COLLECTIVE MAINTENANCE

DHOLAVIRA ADAPTS RESERVOIRS TO ARIDITY; MOHENJO-DARO STRESSES WELLS AND

PLANNED STREETS + STANDARD BRICKS + PLATFORMS + COURTYARD HOUSES wells/reservoirs → bathing areas

soak pits/inspection access household investment collective maintenance

Dholavira adapts reservoirs to aridity; Mohenjo-daro stresses wells and drains.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

PLANNED STREETS + STANDARD BRICKS + PLATFORMS + COURTYARD HOUSES wells/reservoirs → bathing areas → covered drains →
soak pits/inspection access household investment collective maintenance

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

Dholavira adapts reservoirs to aridity; Mohenjo-daro stresses wells and drains.
PLANNED STREETS + STANDARD BRICKS + PLATFORMS + COURTYARD HOUSES wells/reservoirs → bathing areas → covered drains →

DEBATE / LEGACY

soak pits/inspection access household investment collective maintenance
Dholavira adapts reservoirs to aridity; Mohenjo-daro stresses wells and drains.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Dholavira adapts reservoirs to aridity; Mohenjo-daro stresses wells and drains.

04

STAGE 04

THE HARAPPAN ECONOMY AS A LINKED SYSTEM

THE HARAPPAN ECONOMY AS A LINKED SYSTEM

AGRICULTURAL-PASTORAL BASE WHEAT/BARLEY CATTLE COTTON FISHING/REGIONAL CROPS

CRAFT WORKSHOPS

CALIBRATED WEIGHTS

BEADS, SHELL, FAIENCE, POTTERY, COPPER/BRONZE; STONE REMAINS IMPORTANT.

AGRICULTURAL-PASTORAL BASE wheat/barley cattle cotton fishing/regional crops

SURPLUS → craft workshops → calibrated weights → seals/transport → exchange

CRAFTS: beads, shell, faience, pottery, copper/bronze; stone remains important.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

AGRICULTURAL-PASTORAL BASE wheat/barley cattle cotton fishing/regional crops
SURPLUS → craft workshops → calibrated weights → seals/transport → exchange

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

CRAFTS: beads, shell, faience, pottery, copper/bronze; stone remains important.
AGRICULTURAL-PASTORAL BASE wheat/barley cattle cotton fishing/regional crops

DEBATE / LEGACY

SURPLUS → craft workshops → calibrated weights → seals/transport → exchange
CRAFTS: beads, shell, faience, pottery, copper/bronze; stone remains important.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CRAFTS: beads, shell, faience, pottery, copper/bronze; stone remains important.

05

STAGE 05

INTERNAL AND OVERSEAS EXCHANGE CORRIDORS

INTERNAL AND OVERSEAS EXCHANGE CORRIDORS

RAW MATERIAL FLOW

INDUS CITIES

COPPER CORRIDOR

PRODUCTION ZONES

SHELL, CARNELIAN, COASTAL ROUTES

CRAFTS AND PORTS

MESOPOTAMIA; MELUHHA IN CUNEIFORM TEXTS

RAW MATERIAL FLOW

Baluchistan/Afghanistan → metals/stones → Indus cities

Rajasthan/Khetri → copper corridor → production zones

Gujarat/Kutch → shell, carnelian, coastal routes → crafts and ports

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

RAW MATERIAL FLOW
Baluchistan/Afghanistan → metals/stones → Indus cities
Rajasthan/Khetri → copper corridor → production zones

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

Gujarat/Kutch → shell, carnelian, coastal routes → crafts and ports
Indus/Makran/Gulf → Dilmun/Magan → Mesopotamia; Meluhha in cuneiform texts
Trade evidence = imports + texts + seals + production; it does not prove colonies.

DEBATE / LEGACY

Lothal basin has dockyard/reservoir interpretations: state the debate.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Lothal basin has dockyard/reservoir interpretations: state the debate.

06

STAGE 06

SOCIETY AND POLITY: EVIDENCE WITHOUT INVENTED KINGS

SOCIETY AND POLITY

EVIDENCE WITHOUT INVENTED KINGS

HOUSE VARIATION + SCARCE GOODS + CRAFT CONTROL +

NO SECURE PALACE, ROYAL TOMB OR DECIPHERED KING-LIST; HIERARCHY

COORDINATED INSTITUTIONS ARE CERTAIN; EMPIRE-LEVEL SOVEREIGNTY IS UNPROVEN.

SOURCE / MATERIAL

EVIDENCE: house variation + scarce goods + craft control + standards + public works centralised state?
city/regional states?

METHOD / DEBATE

corporate or mercantile elites?
NO secure palace, royal tomb or deciphered king-list; hierarchy existed, form is open.

HISTORICAL RESULT

VERDICT: coordinated institutions are certain; empire-level sovereignty is unproven.
EVIDENCE: house variation + scarce goods + craft control + standards + public works centralised state?

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: coordinated institutions are certain; empire-level sovereignty is unproven.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: coordinated institutions are certain; empire-level sovereignty is unproven.

07

STAGE 07

SCRIPT, SEALS AND RELIGION: EVIDENCE LADDER

SCRIPT, SEALS AND RELIGION

EVIDENCE LADDER

SHORT SIGNS, SEALS/TABLETS, MOTIFS, RITUAL INSTALLATIONS, BURIALS, FIGURINES

IDENTITY/TRANSACTION MARKING AND DIFFERENTIATED RITUAL PRACTICES

SCRIPT LANGUAGE; PROTO-SHIVA; MOTHER-GODDESS SYSTEM; UNIVERSAL FIRE ALTARS

READING LATER HINDU DOCTRINE DIRECTLY INTO EVERY HARAPPAN IMAGE.

UNDECIPHERED SCRIPT BLOCKS DIRECT ACCESS TO OFFICE, BELIEF AND

USE OBJECT + CONTEXT + DISTRIBUTION BEFORE ANALOGY.

SOURCE / MATERIAL

SECURE: short signs, seals/tablets, motifs, ritual installations, burials, figurines
PROBABLE: identity/transaction marking and differentiated ritual practices

METHOD / DEBATE

DISPUTED: script language; proto-Shiva; mother-goddess system; universal fire altars
REJECT: reading later Hindu doctrine directly into every Harappan image.

HISTORICAL RESULT

Undeciphered script blocks direct access to office, belief and political vocabulary.
Use object + context + distribution before analogy.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Use object + context + distribution before analogy.

08

STAGE 08

DE-URBANISATION: INTERACTING REGIONAL CAUSES

INTERACTING REGIONAL CAUSES

RIVER SHIFTS/FLOODS + ARIDIFICATION + EXCHANGE CONTRACTION + MAINTENANCE

CITY CONTRACTION/ABANDONMENT

SETTLEMENT REDISTRIBUTION LOSS

SCRIPT, SEALS, LARGE CITIES CONTINUITY

CROPS, CRAFTS, VILLAGES

NO INVASION OR SINGLE RIVER EXPLAINS ALL REGIONS; TIMINGS

river shifts/floods + aridification + exchange contraction + maintenance stress weaker standards → city contraction/abandonment

loss: script, seals, large cities continuity; crops, crafts, villages

No invasion or single river explains all regions; timings and outcomes differ.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

river shifts/floods + aridification + exchange contraction + maintenance stress weaker standards → city contraction/abandonment → settlement redistribution
loss: script, seals, large cities continuity; crops, crafts, villages

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

No invasion or single river explains all regions, timings and outcomes differ.
river shifts/floods + aridification + exchange contraction + maintenance stress weaker standards → city contraction/abandonment → settlement redistribution

DEBATE / LEGACY

loss: script, seals, large cities continuity; crops, crafts, villages
No invasion or single river explains all regions; timings and outcomes differ.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: No invasion or single river explains all regions; timings and outcomes differ.

09

STAGE 09

HARAPPAN ANSWER ARCHITECTURE: 10/15/20 MARKS

HARAPPAN ANSWER ARCHITECTURE

10/15/20 MARKS

10 MARKS

SITE-FEATURE TRIAD

INTERPRETATION CAUTION

15 MARKS

SPATIAL SYSTEM

URBAN FORM

10 MARKS: phase → site-feature triad → mechanism → interpretation caution

15 MARKS: chronology → spatial system → urban form → economy → polity/region limits

20 MARKS: integration → site map → urban-rural economy → water/standards/trade

society-polity evidence → script/ritual limits → transformation

BENCHMARK: material uniformity indicates integration, not automatic political unity.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

10 MARKS: phase → site-feature triad → mechanism → interpretation caution
15 MARKS: chronology → spatial system → urban form → economy → polity/region limits

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

20 MARKS: integration → site map → urban-rural economy → water/standards/trade
society-polity evidence → script/ritual limits → transformation

DEBATE / LEGACY

BENCHMARK: material uniformity indicates integration, not automatic political unity.
CLOSE: a varied civilisation coordinated by standards, exchange and maintenance.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE: a varied civilisation coordinated by standards, exchange and maintenance.

E

EXTRA

SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT

1. SNAPSHOT & CORE IDEA

2. DEBATES & INTERPRETATIONS (HIGH-YIELD TABLE)

GENETICS AND HARAPPAN/VEDIC QUESTIONS — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

3. STUDY LINKS

4. MUST-KNOW FACTS (PRELIMS)

+ EXACT PYQ APPLICATION (2025 GS-I)

5. UPSC TRAPS

OPTIONAL SOURCE DEPTH

Mini-timeline
1. Snapshot & core idea
2. Debates & interpretations (high-yield table)
Genetics and Harappan/Vedic Questions — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

ADVANCED DEBATE

3. Study links
4. Must-Know Facts (Prelims)
Exact PYQ application (2025 GS-I)
5. UPSC Traps

LEGACY / NUANCE

7. Mains angles
Optional Advanced Studios: Distinct Refinements — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]
A1. Urbanism, Households and Craft — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]
A2. Standardisation and Authority — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.